Niklas Luhmann and His Working Zettelkasten

TDM 155AI Making Stuff in the Age of AI
Week 5 Research and preparation

A collection that changes the question

A research pack begins with a question and a pile of things that might help answer it. The harder problem arrives later: how can material gathered for one purpose become useful for another? Niklas Luhmann's Zettelkasten offers a concrete answer. Stable addresses, branching sequences, and selective references allowed old notes to enter new relationships. Studying the surviving collection also reveals the labor that makes this possible. A box can preserve unfinished thought; its user must still decide what a connection means.

Luhmann's example is particularly useful for students preparing creative projects because the collection could grow without requiring a finished plan. Its arrangements supported an evolving sociological investigation. They did not supply a universal recipe for creativity. The small route examined here concerns the box itself: a cluster in his second collection where he asks how storage, reading, and intellectual productivity interact. It lets us examine both a working arrangement and the claims its maker made about it.

The collection comprises roughly 90,000 handwritten slips, mainly DIN A6, approximately 105 × 148 mm. Current Bielefeld descriptions date Zettelkasten I principally to 1952–1961 and Zettelkasten II to 1961–1997; the first contains about 23,000 slips, the second about 67,000. These are collection periods, not dates for individual notes. Earlier scholarship offered somewhat different boundaries, including 1951–1962 and 1963–1997. Late additions to the first collection further complicate a clean succession. [1, 2, 3]

"Two collections" does not mean two wooden boxes. Schmidt's early survey describes six wooden cabinets with four drawers each, plus separate bibliographical card boxes. Thin paper, sometimes cut from previously used sheets, kept the bulk manageable. The archive now presents 27 drawers or equivalent units, each holding approximately 2,500–3,500 slips; its inventory distinguishes external containers from the wooden drawers. Physical inventory and intellectual organization count different things. [2, 4]

The first collection has 108 numbered subject divisions. The second has eleven broad starting divisions, including organization theory, functionalism, decision theory, and ad hoc notes. Its subsections can acquire longer numerical prefixes. These arrangements bear the history of Luhmann's interests rather than an exhaustive classification of knowledge. Both collections use stable identifiers, branching additions, cross-references, and keyword registers. The second also contains publication drafts, three bibliographical divisions, and four versions of its keyword register. [5, 6]

Adding and finding a note

An identifier supplies an address. In ZK I, the main division and subsequent number are typically separated by a comma, as in 1,1; in ZK II, by a slash, as in 1/1. Further letters and numbers allow insertion between existing slips. Luhmann's published example starts with 57/12 and 57/13; 57/12a opens an addition, followed by 57/12b, while 57/12a1 adds another development inside that sequence. Small red characters mark attachment points. [7]

An address therefore preserves a position while permitting an argument to branch. It does not, by itself, establish the content's place in a conceptual hierarchy. Following a note's immediate physical neighbor can interrupt a line of argument with its elaborations; following the argument can require skipping those insertions. References to distant addresses provide a different movement across the collection. Near continuation and distant connection perform distinct kinds of work.

Reading contributed material through more than one stage. Schmidt describes Luhmann transforming preliminary reading records into slips for integration, rather than simply filing everything in reading order. The destination could be decided while rewriting. Bibliographical slips identify sources; many in the regular bibliography of ZK II carry brief reading notes on their backs. Earlier notes often stay closer to continuous exposition; from the 1970s they become more compressed and thesis-like. [2, 3]

The material practice was less tidy than a diagram of "literature notes" and "permanent notes" suggests. The archive reports that, probably into the 1970s, Luhmann reused the backs of bibliographical entries for substantive slips. Bibliographical records consequently survive dispersed through ZK II as well as in separate sections. Source-derived reflection and his own theoretical thinking also coexist within substantive notes. Neither physical separation nor a rigid division between borrowed knowledge and original ideas describes the whole collection. [6]

To enter, Luhmann could consult a keyword register or return through a source reference. The register offered selected starting addresses, typically one to four per term, rather than every occurrence. Local sequences and reference slips then widened the search. Schmidt distinguishes outline references, collective lists of addresses, and individual references embedded in notes. He also describes updating existing links and replacing an increasingly disorderly alphabetical register. Retrieval depended on maintenance. [3]

Today's archive adds another layer. Its tutorial distinguishes original physical order, numbering, and editorially reconstructed logical strands; full-text search and the archive's detailed contents outline supply additional entrances. These are aids for our reading of Luhmann. They should not be projected backward as tools he possessed. The route below uses those distinctions explicitly. [8]

A short walk through actual slips

Begin at ZK II 9/8, whose heading treats the Zettelkasten as a cybernetic system. Its text combines order and disorder, clustering and combinations realized in a particular act of access. Registers, questions, and incoming ideas can overlay the existing material's arrangement. A red 1 points to the supplementary sequence beginning 9/8,1. The archive's logical navigation also continues to 9/8a; these two movements are visibly distinct in its transcription and data. [9]

The slips are undated. The editorial note attached to 9/8 proposes that most of this cluster was created in 1980/81 in connection with the manuscript of "Kommunikation mit Zettelkästen." That proposal is an attribution, not a dated inscription on every slip. We are examining a mature user's reflection on his practice, not an instruction sheet securely dated to the system's beginning. [9]

At 9/8a, productivity becomes a question about the relationship between collection and user. This is a short but consequential claim: neither the number of cards nor their arrangement can explain an intellectual result alone. Its little branch, 9/8a1, remarks on the collection's continual growth and Luhmann's attempt to benefit from it within his capacities. Growth exceeds complete mastery. The modest admission deserves attention alongside the famous image of an immensely productive sociologist. [10, 11]

Continue to 9/8a2. Here Luhmann calls the collection a Klärgrube, a settling or septic tank. He says clarified notes need not be its only contents; checking and deciding can be deferred, partly for reasons of tempo. The metaphor gives unfinished material somewhere to remain. It also poses a difficulty for a student: postponing evaluation can preserve a possibility, but postponement offers no guarantee that evaluation will ever happen. This is an invitation to return, not permission to stop thinking. [12]

Return to the main strand and continue, passing 9/8b and 9/8c, to 9/8d. This slip observes that attending to possibilities for making slips changes how one reads. Its terse rejection of mere excerpting makes reading prospective: what could this passage do when brought into another discussion? A research pack can likewise become an instrument for asking better questions when its entries record an intended use as well as a source. That application is proposed here, rather than documented as Luhmann's classroom method. [13]

The next slip, 9/8e, suggests an information concept dependent on comparison schemes that cannot be fixed in advance. The collection becomes productive when what has been recorded encounters backgrounds that were not recorded with it; information can arise that was never stored in that form. This explains how the same sentence can become newly useful without changing its words. A different question changes what the sentence allows the reader to notice. [14]

Our interpretive route has therefore moved from arrangement, through the user's limited capacities and deferred judgment, to reading and contextual information. It suggests a question for the exhibition: how much of preparation consists in making material easy to retrieve, and how much in keeping it available for a use one cannot yet specify? This question is our construction from the slips. It is not evidence that Luhmann followed this exact route on a particular day.

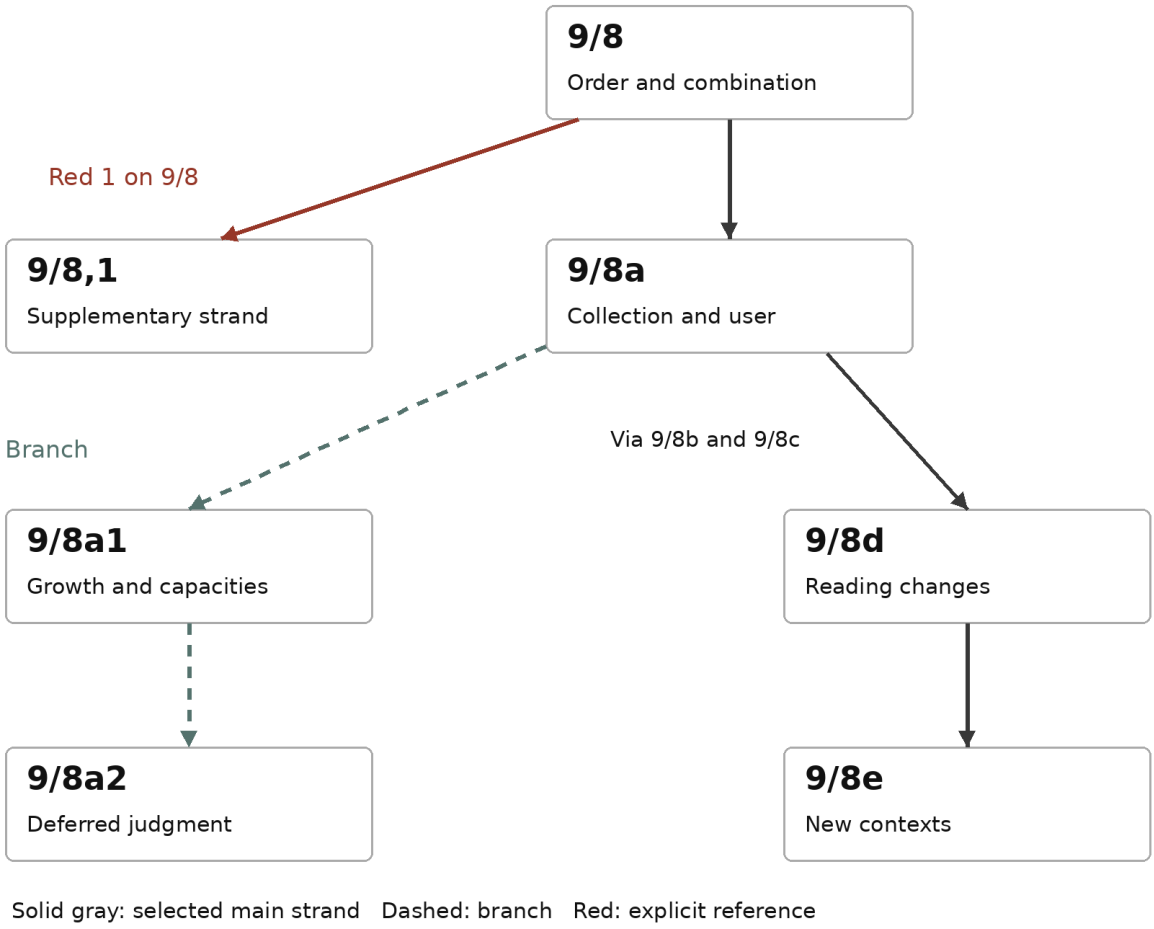


Figure 1. Selected relationships in ZK II 9/8. Gray arrows follow the archive's logical main strand; 9/8b and 9/8c are omitted. Dashed arrows show the branch through 9/8a1 and 9/8a2. Only the red arrow represents an explicit handwritten reference verified on 9/8. This is an editorial diagram, not a record of Luhmann's reading itinerary. Sources [8–14].

From the collection to a publication

A defensible publication connection lies close at hand. ZK II 9/8g associates writing with demanding thought that anticipates selective access to memory. The opening page of the 1981 essay, p. 222, likewise connects writing, preserved distinctions, and continued intellectual work. The archive's probable 1980/81 dating of the cluster strengthens the association. It does not establish whether the slip preceded a manuscript sentence or condensed an argument already being drafted. [9, 15, 7]

Reading also enters the publication's apparatus. Schmidt associates 9/8b with W. Ross Ashby's account of memory; the essay cites Ashby's 1967 "The Place of the Brain in the Natural World" in its third endnote, p. 228. This is evidence of a shared source and problem, not a complete reconstruction of composition. The box and manuscript can exchange material in both directions. [3, 7]

The published essay explicitly says, on p. 227, that publications do not arise through copying out stored notes. On p. 226, it gives the box years to acquire sufficient complexity. [7] These qualifications matter. A convincing account of a book's emergence would have to compare slips, drafts, revisions, and final prose. Identifying similar language establishes a relationship; assigning the invention of an argument to a particular card requires more evidence.

9/8a2

Admit unfinished material

Judgment can be deferred.
Tempo matters.

9/8e

Revisit the material

A new context can produce
information not stored before.

Figure 2. Two operations in the cluster: admitting unresolved material and returning under new conditions. These are English paraphrases of 9/8a2 and 9/8e, set in contemporary typography; they are not facsimiles or a historical sequence of actions. Sources [12, 14].

Contemporary methods and the work of returning

Contemporary Zettelkasten teaching often recommends discrete ideas, reusable notes, and explicit links. Sascha Fast's introduction on Zettelkasten.de presents atomicity as a guiding principle rather than an inflexible law. That is a contemporary formulation. Luhmann's short slips, branching elaborations, reference lists, and variations across periods support the value of manageable units, but do not establish one obligatory size or template. Our cluster even includes an admission and a pungent metaphor alongside theoretical propositions. [16]

Stable addresses, manually selected cross-references, branching sequences, and a keyword index are documented features. Automatic backlinks belong to digital implementations: Obsidian, for example, displays incoming links and unlinked mentions. Luhmann wrote references and return references by hand. A software-generated incoming-link list can reduce retrieval labor; it cannot establish why a mention is intellectually significant. Exhaustive tagging, mandatory title conventions, or a prescribed daily note quota should be identified as adaptations unless independently demonstrated in the historical evidence. [7, 17]

Friction also has a history. Paper requires physical movement; a drawer's sequence can separate the continuation of a thought from its initial slip. Luhmann's own account acknowledges notes that disappear from use. [7] Their survival in a cabinet is not the same as

their availability to a working mind. The relevant cost includes returning to old formulations, discovering that they are unclear, and deciding which relations still deserve attention.

The theatre-maker may consequently want a different arrangement. This is a proposed adaptation. A sociological argument needs concepts whose relations withstand criticism; a rehearsal process may need a gesture, a sound, a disputed character motivation, or an observation about an audience. Preserve photographs and audio beside written reflections. Let links identify tensions or possible tests in rehearsal. A shared collection also needs authorship and dates so collaborators can distinguish observation from proposal. The test of a connection can become a scene performed in a room.

A manageable experiment with links

Over one week, make twelve paper slips or Markdown files for a current project. Give each a stable identifier. Record a claim, observation, image description, or question, together with its source and locator where applicable. Include two unresolved or contradictory entries. As new material arrives, put it beside a related entry or link it to one; write a sentence explaining the relation. Make a keyword list with three entrances. These numbers are a classroom constraint, not Luhmann's rules.

Leave the collection for two days. Return through one keyword and follow three connections. Produce a 150-word argument or a one-minute rehearsal proposal. Log one surprise, one dead end, and the time spent retrieving material. Then add a thirteenth note that challenges the route's strongest claim. Success means being able to explain a change in the project's question, including a useful reason to reject a connection.

Run a second pass with AI, asking it to suggest three links between named entries and explain each using their actual contents. Mark these as suggestions; retain only links you can defend. Compare whether AI finds a relevant relation you missed or mostly repeats shared vocabulary. A fluent explanation can obscure a missing source, a contradiction, or the difference between evidence and speculation. It can also make unlike materials sound prematurely compatible.

The experiment tests a possibility rather than reproducing decades of work. AI may accelerate the proposal of connections and help locate neglected material. Keep the act of accepting a link visible, and preserve the question that made it useful. A collection becomes an intellectual system when returning to its materials changes what its user can ask.

Wall label

150 words

Niklas Luhmann’s Zettelkasten held roughly 90,000 handwritten slips in two collections, developed from the 1950s to 1997. Each note had a stable address; branches, references, and keyword registers allowed material gathered for one question to enter another discussion. The system required rewriting, retrieval, and maintenance. Some notes remained unfinished; some disappeared from use.

This exhibition follows a small cluster where Luhmann reflects on the box itself. He describes productivity as a relationship between collection and user, permits deferred judgment, and asks how old entries produce information through new contexts. The archive connects these undated slips, probably mostly from 1980/81, to his published account of communicating with slip-boxes.

For your project, try twelve slips or files. Explain each connection, return after an interval, and record what surprises you. AI can suggest links; your task is to decide what they mean and whether they can survive a test in writing or rehearsal.

Sources: collection dates [1]; navigation [8]; slips and proposed dating [9–15]. The final paragraph proposes a student experiment.

Four visual candidates

Original handwritten slips from Zettelkasten II, all in physical drawer 15. Credit each reproduction to Universität Bielefeld / Niklas-Luhmann-Archiv. Each original is undated; the archive proposes that most of the cluster arose in 1980/81. The digital edition dates from 2021. These candidates are identified for image selection; the original facsimiles are not embedded in this packet.

1 A stable address and a red attachment point

Identifier: ZK II 9/8 • Archive ID: ZK_2_NB_9-8_V

The heading treats the collection as a cybernetic system. The red 1 beside Zettelkasten points to 9/8,1; it is a reference marker, not the number of the collection. Show the full slip so the address, heading, and mark remain legible.

View the original slip and download options

2 Productivity between user and collection

Identifier: ZK II 9/8a • Archive ID: ZK_2_NB_9-8a_V

This brief slip places the problem of productivity in the relation between collection and user. Pair it with the diagram's branch to 9/8a1 and 9/8a2; the slip provides a proposition, while the diagram interprets its position in a strand.

View the original slip and download options

3 Allowing unfinished thought to settle

Identifier: ZK II 9/8a2 • Archive ID: ZK_2_NB_9-8a2_V

Luhmann's Klärgrube metaphor permits material whose evaluation remains open. The note ties postponing judgment to tempo. It complicates the idea that every filed note must already be polished and fully resolved.

View the original slip and download options

4 Writing prepares later thinking

Identifier: ZK II 9/8g • Archive ID: ZK_2_NB_9-8g_V

A reflection on writing and selective access to memory. Compare it with the opening of the 1981 essay, p. 222; the resemblance supports a connection without proving which formulation came first.

View the original slip and download options

Research basis and image status

This essay uses the archive's indexed transcriptions and metadata, its tutorial, Luhmann's original German essay, and Schmidt's scholarship. Direct facsimile access was blocked in this research environment. Consequently, no claim here depends on an uninspected visual detail beyond the archive's transcription of the red reference on 9/8. Figures 1 and 2 are explicitly labeled reconstructions. English renderings of the slips are paraphrases unless identified as quotations. Source access: 5 October 2026.

Sources and reading

[1] Bielefeld University Library. Der Zettelkasten Niklas Luhmanns. Collection dates and approximate counts; current institutional description.

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[3] Johannes F. K. Schmidt. Niklas Luhmann's Card Index The Fabrication of Serendipity. Sociologica 12.1 (2018), 53–60, especially 54–58. DOI 10.6092/issn.1971-8853/8350. Integration, reference types, keyword index, and historical dating.

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https://niklas-luhmann-archiv.de/bestand/zettelkasten/auszuege

[5] Niklas Luhmann Archive. Inhaltsübersicht ZK II. Editorial overview distinguishing the two collections and their apparatus. Accessed 5 October 2026.

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[6] Niklas Luhmann Archive. Der Zettelkasten Niklas Luhmanns. Scholarly collection description, especially organization and bibliography. Accessed 5 October 2026.

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[7] Niklas Luhmann. Kommunikation mit Zettelkästen Ein Erfahrungsbericht. In Horst Baier, Hans Mathias Kepplinger, and Kurt Reumann, eds., Öffentliche Meinung und sozialer Wandel. Opladen: Westdeutscher Verlag, 1981, 222–228. DOI 10.1007/978-3-322-87749-9_19. Original German consulted; scan hosted by Christian Krybus.

https://ckrybus.com/static/papers/luhmann1981.pdf

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https://niklas-luhmann-archiv.de/bestand/zettelkasten/tutorial

[9] Niklas Luhmann. ZK II 9/8. Undated. Editorial note proposes most of the cluster originated in 1980/81; edition published 2021. Archive API confirms the explicit red reference and distinguishes navigation types.

https://niklas-luhmann-archiv.de/bestand/zettelkasten/zettel/ZK_2_NB_9-8_V

[10] Niklas Luhmann. ZK II 9/8a. Undated. Productivity as a relation between collection and user.

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[11] Niklas Luhmann. ZK II 9/8a1. Undated. Continual growth and the user's capacities. Archive version 25, 23 May 2026.

https://niklas-luhmann-archiv.de/bestand/zettelkasten/zettel/ZK_2_NB_9-8a1_V

[12] Niklas Luhmann. ZK II 9/8a2. Undated. Klärgrube and postponed evaluation. Archive version 25, 23 May 2026.

https://niklas-luhmann-archiv.de/bestand/zettelkasten/zettel/ZK_2_NB_9-8a2_V

[13] Niklas Luhmann. ZK II 9/8d. Undated. Effects of making slips on reading.

https://niklas-luhmann-archiv.de/bestand/zettelkasten/zettel/ZK_2_NB_9-8d_V

[14] Niklas Luhmann. ZK II 9/8e. Undated. Recorded notes meeting unrecorded backgrounds.

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[15] Niklas Luhmann. ZK II 9/8g. Undated. Writing and selective access to memory. Digitized edition 2021.

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